

Congressional Attention to Abortion after *Dobbs*: A Theory of Representational and Party Incentive Alignment

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Abstract

Landmark Supreme Court rulings can reshape policy, rights, and public opinion, but their effects on congressional issue attention remain less clear. We develop an incentive-alignment theory of congressional issue attention, arguing that judicial decisions linked to identity-salient issues reshape attention selectively when legislators' gender-linked and party incentives align. We test this argument using *Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health Organization* (2022). After *Dobbs*, Democratic female legislators faced reinforcing incentives: abortion was both gender-salient and electorally advantageous for Democrats to foreground. Republican female legislators faced cross-cutting incentives: abortion remained gender-salient but became electorally risky for Republicans. Treating the leaked draft opinion as the shock date, we estimate differential within-legislator changes in abortion attention across party and gender using nearly 1.6 million legislator statements from U.S. House committee hearings. Pre-leak trends show no systematic differences across groups. After the leak, Democratic female legislators increased abortion-related references relative to Republican female legislators; pooled triple-interaction models further show that this party-based increase was significantly larger among female legislators than among male legislators.

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On May 2, 2022, a draft opinion in *Dobbs v. Jackson Women’s Health Organization* was leaked to the public. Two months later, the Supreme Court issued its official decision, overturning *Roe* and *Casey* and eliminating the federal constitutional right to abortion. The decision immediately reshaped abortion politics in the United States: it altered the policy status quo, intensified media and public attention (Levendusky, Patterson Jr, Margolis, Pasek, Winneg and Jamieson 2024), and created new incentives for elected officials to foreground—or avoid—one of the most salient issues in American politics (Meisels 2025; Gardner, McCrary and Spencer 2025). Existing work shows that these effects fell largely along party lines. After *Dobbs*, Republicans’ trust in and perceived legitimacy of the Court increased, while Democrats’ evaluations declined (Clark, Paluck, Westwood, Sen, Malhotra and Jessee 2024; Gibson 2025; Levendusky et al. 2024). The ruling also reshaped candidates’ campaign strategies along party lines: Democratic candidates increasingly emphasized abortion, while Republican candidates attempted to avoid the issue (Meisels 2025).

Yet the extent to which landmark Supreme Court rulings influence congressional issue attention remains unclear. Although scholars have shown that political actors strategically communicate about high court decisions (Rivero and Stone 2026), we know less about whether such decisions reshape congressional attention itself—and, if so, which legislators respond. We develop an incentive-alignment theory of congressional issue attention to explain why these responses should be selective rather than uniform. We argue that landmark judicial decisions linked to identity-salient issues should increase attention most clearly when legislators’ identity-linked representational incentives and party-based electoral incentives align. In the case of abortion, the relevant representational incentive is gender-linked: abortion is both a gender-salient issue and a deeply partisan one. *Dobbs* therefore provides a useful case for evaluating how gender-linked representational incentives and party-based electoral incentives jointly shape congressional issue attention.

Our argument integrates two literatures that are often considered separately. First, research on descriptive representation shows that female legislators often bring distinct perspectives to gender-salient policy domains, including reproductive health, women’s rights, and social welfare (Swers 2020; Reingold 2000; Osborn 2012; Swers 2013; Lawless 2015). Abortion is central to this litera-

ture because it directly implicates women's autonomy and reproductive health (Rolfes-Haase and Swers 2022; Swers 2023). A gender-only account would therefore predict that female legislators in both parties should increase attention to abortion after *Dobbs*, even if they do so in different ideological directions (e.g., pro-life v. pro-choice).

However, parties shape how female legislators experience and act on gender-linked incentives. Political parties shape which women's issues legislators prioritize, how those issues are framed, and whether gender-linked representation is rewarded or constrained (Osborn 2012). This party-gender interaction is especially important for abortion. Over time, abortion has moved from a cross-cutting issue to a highly partisan issue, with reproductive rights central to the Democratic Party and abortion restrictions central to the Republican Party (Rolfes-Haase and Swers 2022; Swers 2023). After *Dobbs*, these partisan differences became electorally asymmetric. Democratic candidates increasingly foregrounded abortion, while Republican candidates largely attempted to avoid it (Meisels 2025). Republican candidates also faced electoral costs in states with abortion-related ballot measures, suggesting that foregrounding abortion was politically risky for the party after *Dobbs* (Gardner, McCrary and Spencer 2025). As a result, a party-only account would predict greater abortion attention among Democratic legislators than Republican legislators.

Applying this framework to *Dobbs*, Democratic female legislators faced reinforcing incentives. As female legislators, they had gender-linked incentives to speak to a policy issue affecting reproductive autonomy. As Democrats, they had party incentives to foreground an issue on which Democratic candidates and constituencies mobilized.

Republican female legislators provide the clearest case of incentive misalignment after *Dobbs*: their gender-linked representational incentives conflicted with their party-based electoral incentives. Female Republicans are often cross-pressured because gendered expectations to engage women's issues can conflict with the Republican Party's policy positions (Swers and Thomsen 2025). A similar pattern emerged during the Kavanaugh confirmation. After sexual assault allegations made the Supreme Court conflict newly gender-salient, Democratic female senators increased partisan attention to the allegations, while Republican female senators attempted to ignore it (Gel-

man 2021). In the case of *Dobbs*, abortion remained gender-salient, giving Republican female legislators a representational basis for engaging the issue. But *Dobbs* also made abortion electorally risky for Republicans (Meisels 2025; Gardner, McCrary and Spencer 2025). Although gender-linked incentives should have made abortion salient, party-based electoral incentives encouraged avoidance.

The central implication of our incentive-alignment theory is that landmark judicial decisions should produce selective, rather than uniform, shifts in congressional attention. We expect attention to increase most clearly when gender-linked and party incentives align. This alignment was strongest among female Democrats. Male Democrats had party incentives to foreground abortion but weaker gender-linked incentives. Republican male legislators had neither strong gender-linked incentives nor party incentives to foreground the issue. Republican female legislators are the key cross-pressured group: their gender-linked incentives should have made abortion salient, but their party incentives encouraged avoidance. Accordingly, we expect Democratic female legislators to increase their attention to abortion after *Dobbs* more than the other three groups, with especially sharp differences relative to Republican female legislators. Table 1 details our theoretical expectations for legislators' attention to abortion after *Dobbs* based on party and gender.

Table 1: Incentive Alignment Theory of Congressional Issue Attention

	Gender-Linked Incentive	Party Incentive	Expected Change in Abortion Attention
Democratic female legislators	Strong	Reinforcing	Largest increase
Republican female legislators	Strong	Constraining	Muted attention or decline
Democratic male legislators	Weaker	Reinforcing	Modest increase
Republican male legislators	Weaker	Constraining	No change or decline

To evaluate these expectations, we identify abortion references in nearly 1.6 million legislator statements from U.S. House committee hearings spanning the 105th (1997) through the 119th (2025) Congresses. We define a statement as a single, uninterrupted speaking turn by a legislator in a hearing transcript.¹ Committee hearings are a useful venue for measuring congressional issue attention because they offer legislators a relatively unconstrained opportunity to discuss a range of policy issues.²

Using an interrupted time series (ITS) design, we estimate whether *Dobbs* produced differential within-legislator changes in abortion attention across party and gender groups. Because all legislators were exposed to the leaked draft opinion, our design does not compare treated and untreated units or estimate the absolute effect of *Dobbs*. Instead, we estimate whether this common shock generated differential changes in abortion attention based on legislators' party and gender. To identify the timing of the shock, we measure monthly abortion-related coverage in *New York Times* articles and legislators' electronic newsletters, both of which increased sharply after the leaked draft opinion on May 2, 2022.

The results show that congressional attention to abortion shifted selectively after *Dobbs*. Pre-treatment tests show no evidence of differential trends in abortion attention across party and gender groups prior to the leak. After *Dobbs*, Democratic female legislators increased their abortion-related references more than the other three groups, while Republican female legislators reduced attention relative to Republican male legislators. These patterns also appear in cosponsorship of abortion-related bills, suggesting that the results are not limited to committee speech. Together, the results demonstrate that landmark judicial decisions can reshape congressional attention, but not uniformly. In the case of *Dobbs*, legislators responded selectively because gender-linked and party incentives aligned for some legislators while cutting against one another for others.

¹We exclude witness statements, opening statements, and evidence submitted for the record.

²Although committee chairs set hearing agendas, legislators can, and often do, discuss issues beyond the formal scope of the hearing. Legislators also retain substantial discretion over the content of their questions and remarks. To address concerns that committee hearings may capture committee-specific agenda constraints rather than broader issue attention, we also assess an alternative measure of issue attention: cosponsorship of abortion-related bills. See Appendix Table 10.

Research Design

We identify whether nearly 1.6 million committee hearing statements drawn from 17,408 hearings in the U.S. House of Representatives from the 105th through the 119th Congress reference abortion (Park 2021; Lollis 2025).³ To label statements, we employ a bigram dictionary classification method (Lollis 2025). First, we created a training set of randomly sampled statements ($n = 20,000$) and prompted GPT-5 to label whether each referenced abortion.⁴ Human coders then labeled a 2,000-statement subset of the training set, confirming that GPT-5 correctly classified abortion statements ($AUC = 0.94$).⁵ We then extracted abortion bigrams ($n = 1,829$)—two-word sequences that indicate abortion (e.g., `pro life`, `abortion ban`, `planned parenthood`)—from the positive training statements and used this dictionary to classify the full corpus.⁶ Comparing GPT-5-coded and bigram-predicted labels in a held-out validation set confirms that the classifier accurately identified abortion statements in the full corpus ($AUC = 0.95$).⁷ In total, the bigram classifier identified 5,036 abortion statements. We construct two measures capturing the proportion of legislators’ committee statements referencing abortion:

- ***Attention to Abortion (Pre–Post Dobbs)***: measures the proportion of a legislator’s hearing statements that reference abortion before and after the *Dobbs* decision leaked.
- ***Attention to Abortion (by Term)***: measures the proportion of a legislator’s hearing statements that reference abortion in each congressional term.

³Our dataset includes all hearings in the 105th–118th Congresses and all hearings held on or before April 29, 2025, in the 119th Congress (the date of collection).

⁴Recent work shows that large language models can perform well on text annotation tasks, including labeling relevance, stance, topics, and framing (Gilardi, Alizadeh and Kubli 2023); we rely on our own validation against human-coded labels to assess performance in this application.

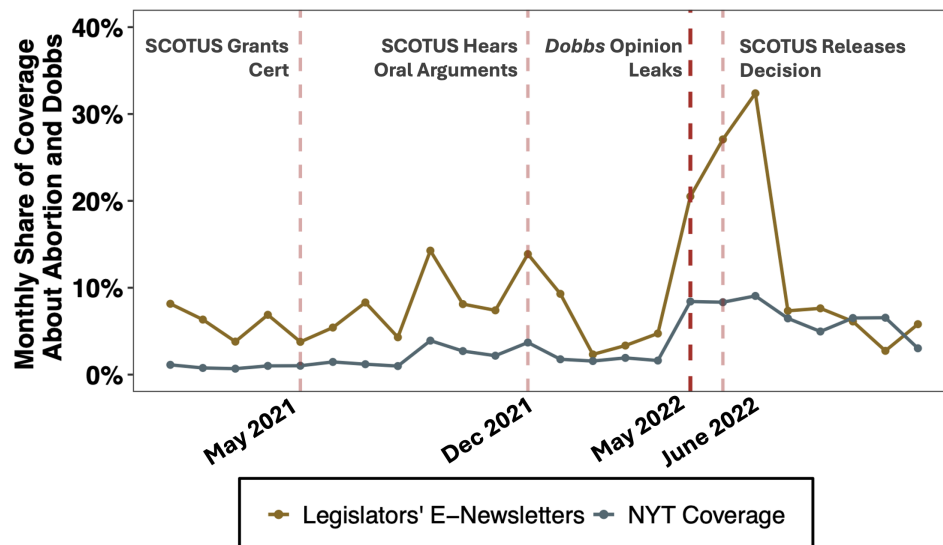
⁵The Area Under the Curve (AUC) measures how well a model distinguishes between positive and negative labels; a value of 1.0 indicates perfect classification.

⁶Because the outcome measures attention rather than position-taking (e.g., pro-life v. pro-choice), it captures whether legislators referenced abortion, not whether those references supported or opposed abortion access. This measurement choice is appropriate for our theoretical focus on issue attention. It also means that pro-life and pro-choice references both count as abortion attention; if Republican female legislators had responded to *Dobbs* by increasing pro-life references, this would appear as an increase in our dependent variable.

⁷Additional validation for the bigram dictionary classifier appears in Appendix Section “Labeling Abortion Statements.”

The interruption date is May 2, 2022, when the draft opinion in *Dobbs* leaked. Before the leak, legislators could not have responded to the ruling’s content because it was not publicly known. To confirm that the leaked decision, rather than the Court’s official decision on June 24, 2022, marked the relevant shock, we compiled the monthly share of *New York Times* (NYT) articles referencing abortion or *Dobbs v. Jackson*, as well as the monthly share of legislators’ e-newsletters referencing the same terms (Cormack 2025). *NYT* coverage of abortion captures when legislators were most likely to learn about the content of the *Dobbs* decision, while legislators’ e-newsletters indicate whether legislators transmitted that information to constituents, offering behavioral evidence that the leak marked the relevant interruption. If the leak served as the relevant shock, the initial spike in coverage and constituent communication should occur in May 2022. Figure 1 confirms this pattern: from April to May 2022, *NYT* abortion coverage rose by 6.8 percentage points, a 425% increase, and legislators’ mentions of abortion in their e-newsletters rose by 19.8 percentage points, a 421% increase.

Figure 1: Determining Interruption Date—NYT Coverage and Legislators’ Newsletters Referencing Abortion



Note: Monthly share of congressional electronic newsletters sent to constituents ($N = 25,680$) and *New York Times* articles ($N = 182,329$), from January 2021 through December 2022, that reference abortion or *Dobbs v. Jackson*. Abortion coverage from both sources rose sharply after the leak, indicating that the disclosure of the draft opinion—not the final decision—informed legislators of the ruling.

We estimate ITS regression models using ordinary least squares with three specifications: (i) pre–post models with legislator fixed effects, estimated separately by gender; (ii) two-way fixed-effects (TWFE) models with legislator and term fixed effects, also estimated separately by gender; and (iii) pooled pre–post and TWFE models with triple interactions, estimated with legislator fixed effects and with both legislator and term fixed effects, to assess whether post-*Dobbs* changes in abortion attention differed jointly by party and gender.

Across our models, the dependent variable is the proportion of a legislator’s committee hearing statements that reference abortion. In the pre–post specifications, each legislator contributes two observations: the proportion of statements referencing abortion before and after *Dobbs*. In the TWFE specifications, the unit of analysis is the legislator-term, with both legislator and term fixed effects. In the models subset by gender, the independent variable of interest is the interaction between a post-*Dobbs* indicator and a Democratic Party indicator. In the pooled models, the independent variable of interest is the triple interaction between the post-*Dobbs*, female, and Democratic Party indicators.

In the models subset by gender, the estimand is the average Democratic-versus-Republican difference in the change in abortion attention from the pre- to post-*Dobbs* period. In the pooled models, the triple interaction captures whether this post-*Dobbs* Democratic-versus-Republican change differs between female and male legislators. We estimate a TWFE model alongside the pre–post specification, despite a single non-staggered shock date, for two reasons. First, term fixed effects absorb cross-term differences in statement volume, which is necessary given that the pre–post model pools more pre-treatment terms (12) than post-treatment terms (3). Second, term fixed effects adjust for time-varying shocks across congressional terms that could confound pre–post estimates. Models are estimated with OLS and robust standard errors clustered by legislator.⁸

We address three important identification threats related to our design. First, some contemporaneous factor other than *Dobbs* could have shifted legislators’ attention across multiple policy areas, including abortion. This possibility is unlikely because such a factor would have needed to

⁸To ensure that committee selection effects or committee-specific issue agendas do not confound our findings, we estimate models including committee fixed effects; see Appendix Table 3. Results remain substantively unchanged.

occur at the same time as the *Dobbs* leak. Nevertheless, to empirically address this concern, we examine whether party- and gender-based shifts occurred at the time of the *Dobbs* leak across six non-abortion policy areas. We find no comparable shifts in attention, providing reassurance that the observed changes are specific to *Dobbs*.⁹

Second, party-by-gender groups may have already been on divergent trajectories in abortion attention before the leak. For example, Democratic female legislators may have been increasing their attention to abortion relative to Republican female legislators prior to *Dobbs*. To evaluate this possibility, we conduct four complementary pre-treatment tests, reported in Figure 2 (Hassell and Holbein 2025).¹⁰ Panel A reports term-specific, pre-*Dobbs* TWFE estimates of the party gap in abortion-related statements, using the 105th Congress as the reference category. There are no statistically significant party differences in the proportion of abortion statements by gender in any pre-*Dobbs* term. Panel B examines whether variation in abortion references by party and gender emerges in the 16 months leading up to the decision, plotting TWFE estimates over this period. January 2021 is the reference category. Again, there are no systematic pre-*Dobbs* differences. Panel C assesses pre-*Dobbs* differences by randomly assigning interruption dates prior to the decision. Across 2,000 simulations, 98% of p-values on the interaction term of interest, Democrat $\times$ Post-*Dobbs*, were not statistically significant, indicating that no party-based differences emerged in abortion references before the leaked decision. Finally, Panel D plots term-based lagged TWFE estimates of party differences in abortion references by gender. None of the lagged interactions are statistically significant, indicating that the effect did not emerge before the leak. Collectively, these tests provide strong evidence that the observed post-*Dobbs* divergence was not preceded by comparable pre-treatment differences.

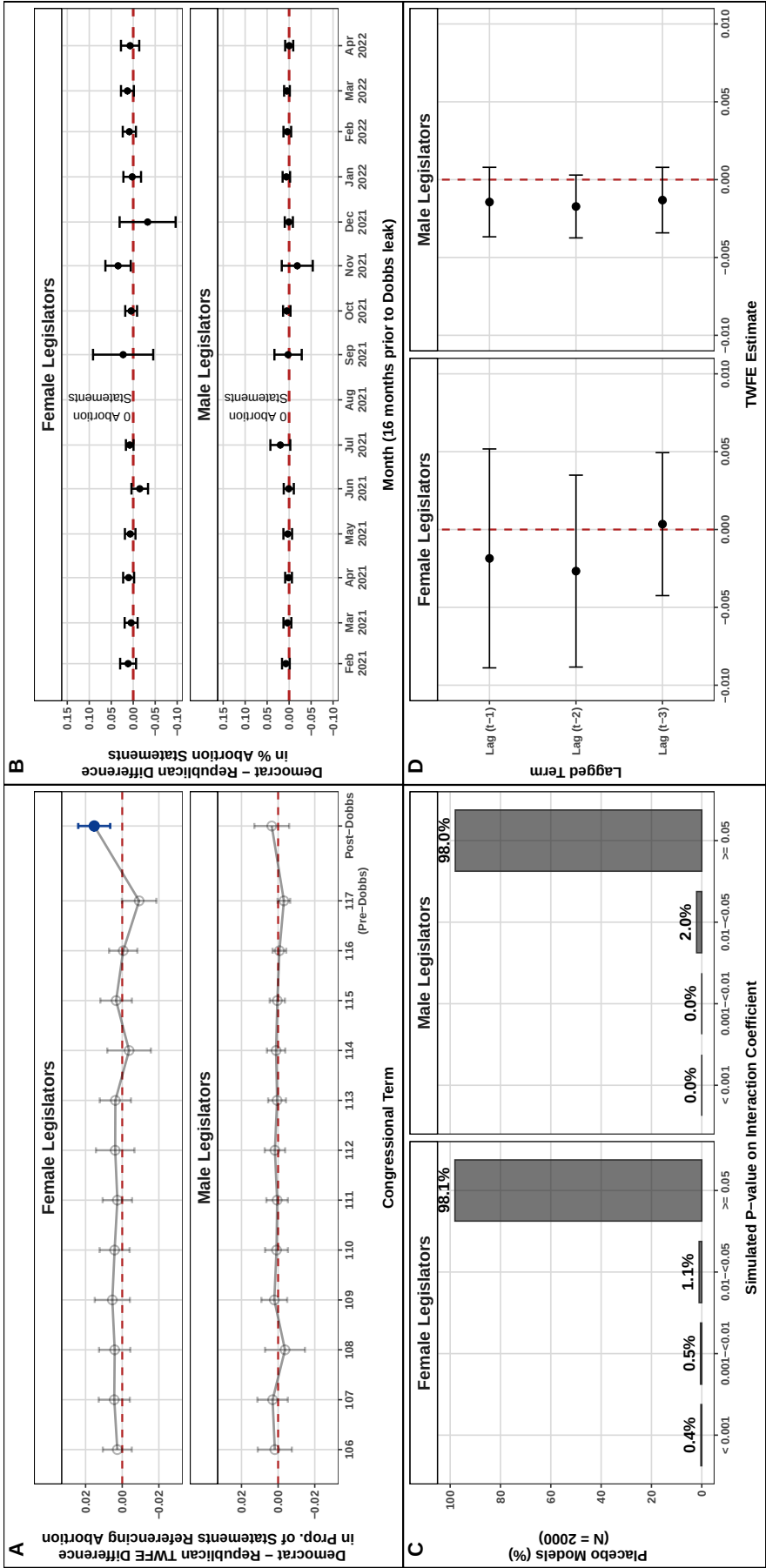
Finally, because our measure of issue attention relies on legislators' statements in committee hearings, committee selection effects, committee policy jurisdictions, or committee-specific agendas could affect whether legislators mention abortion. For example, if a committee chair chose not

⁹See Appendix Section "Placebo Test: Non-Abortion Issue Areas."

¹⁰For a more exhaustive discussion of pre-treatment trend tests for our research design, see Appendix Section "Pre-Treatment Trends"

to hold hearings related to abortion after *Dobbs*, legislators on that committee may have had fewer opportunities to discuss abortion. As a result, the party- and gender-based differences observed after *Dobbs* could reflect committee-specific factors rather than identity- and electoral-based responses. To address this possibility, we estimate models including committee fixed effects in Appendix Table 3. Results remain substantively unchanged.

Figure 2: Assessing Pre-Dobbs Trends in Abortion Statements



Note: Panels A–D assess the validity of the pre-treatment assumption for our research design. Panel A plots the party-based difference in abortion references using a TWFE model by gender. Panel B presents a 16-month event study reporting party-based differences using a TWFE model estimated by gender. Panel C shows estimated p-values from a simulation in which the treatment date is randomly assigned to 2,000 different pre-Dobbs dates. Panel D reports term-based lagged estimates from a TWFE model. Results indicate that there were no pre-Dobbs differences in abortion references by gender or party.

Results

Table 2 reports estimates for all model specifications; results are consistent across models.¹¹ In the pre–post specification subset by gender, female Republicans’ share of statements referencing abortion decreases by 0.87 percentage points after *Dobbs*, while female Democrats’ share increases by 1.32 percentage points. This yields a party-based difference among female legislators after *Dobbs*, reported as the Post *Dobbs* $\times$ Democrat interaction, of 2.19 percentage points ($p < 0.001$). In the TWFE model, the estimated increase in female Democrats’ abortion references after *Dobbs* is 0.8 percentage points ($p = 0.02$). Both of these models suggest that, relative to female Republicans, female Democrats increased their attention to abortion post-*Dobbs*. Further, across both model specifications subset to include only male legislators, the difference between Democratic and Republican legislators is not statistically significant.

The pooled triple-interaction models provide a formal test of whether this party-based response differs by gender. This test is important because the gender-split models show that the Democratic-versus-Republican change is statistically significant among female legislators but not among male legislators; however, separate subgroup estimates do not themselves establish that the two effects are statistically different from one another. The triple interaction directly tests that difference. In the pooled pre–post model, the coefficient for the Post-*Dobbs* $\times$ Female $\times$ Democrat interaction is 1.7 percentage points ($p < 0.05$), indicating that the post-*Dobbs* Democratic-versus-Republican increase in abortion attention is significantly larger among female legislators than among male legislators. The same pattern appears in the pooled TWFE model, where the coefficient on the triple interaction is 0.8 percentage points ($p < 0.05$). Consistent with our expectations, these results collectively suggest that attention increased most clearly where gender-linked representational incentives and party-based electoral incentives reinforced one another: among Democratic female legislators.

¹¹Table 2 reports only the interaction terms that correspond to the estimands of interest. The components of these interactions (Post-Dobbs, Female, and Democrat) are not individually reported because several are absorbed by the legislator and term fixed effects, and those that remain identified represent reference-group shifts rather than the party- and gender-based changes central to the research design.

Table 2: Party-Based Changes in Abortion Attention Before and After Dobbs by Gender

	Female Legislators		Male Legislators		Pooled	
	Pre-Post	TWFE	Pre-Post	TWFE	Pre-Post	TWFE
Post-Dobbs × Democrat	0.022*** (0.005)	0.008* (0.004)	0.004 (0.005)	−0.0003 (0.001)	—	—
Post-Dobbs × Female × Democrat					0.017* (0.007)	0.008* (0.004)
Legislator FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Term FE	✗	✓	✗	✓	✗	✓
Observations	226	1,117	562	4,562	788	5,679
Adjusted R^2	0.144	0.192	0.037	0.070	0.060	0.079

Note: OLS estimates report party-based changes in abortion attention after *Dobbs* using pre–post and two-way fixed-effects (TWFE) models. The gender-split models estimate the post-*Dobbs* change among Democratic legislators relative to Republican legislators separately for female and male legislators. The pooled models estimate whether this party-based change differs between female and male legislators. Robust standard errors clustered by legislator are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.05$; ** $p < 0.01$; *** $p < 0.001$.

Using pre-*Dobbs* statement volume to benchmark the substantive per-member effects, the model estimates suggest that the average female Democrat makes about 24 additional abortion statements per term after *Dobbs*, while the average female Republican makes about 4 fewer. At the party level, female Democrats collectively made nearly 300 additional abortion statements and female Republicans 100 fewer. This shift is substantively large in the context of congressional abortion attention. To contextualize whether a two percentage point increase in congressional attention to abortion in hearings is substantively meaningful, we estimate shifts in abortion attention around four other influential abortion-related political events in our time series: the Partial-Birth Abortion Ban Act, *Gonzalez v. Carhart*, *Whole Woman’s Health v. Hellerstedt*, and *June Medical Services v. Russo*. The post-*Dobbs* party-based increase among female legislators is approximately ten times larger than the largest comparable change around these other abortion-policy events (see Appendix Section “Contextualizing the Magnitude of the *Dobbs* Effect”).¹²

¹²Although we use hearing statements to measure legislators’ attention to abortion, we do not establish whether increased attention translates into substantive policy change. Increased attention to abortion in hearings may not

We assess the durability of these effects by estimating separate pre–post models for each post-*Dobbs* Congress: the latter half of the 117th, all of the 118th, and the portion of the 119th in our corpus. We then conduct Wald tests of (i) joint significance of all post-*Dobbs* interactions and (ii) equality of effects across the three post-*Dobbs* periods. Consistent with our results, the joint post-*Dobbs* effect is statistically significant for female legislators (Wald $\chi^2(3) = 12.88, p = 0.004$) and not statistically significant for male legislators ($\chi^2(3) = 4.01, p = 0.26$). Effects are not statistically distinguishable across the three post-*Dobbs* periods for either female or male legislators (Female Legislators: $\chi^2(2) = 0.45, p = 0.80$; Male Legislators: $\chi^2(2) = 3.93, p = 0.14$). This indicates that the increase in attention among female Democrats persists through the 119th Congress without detectable decay, while no comparable effect emerges among male legislators.¹³

Finally, to assess whether our findings are specific to committee hearing statements or extend to another measure of issue attention, we examine abortion-related cosponsorship (Appendix Table 10). We collect legislators’ cosponsorship decisions from the 111th–118th Congresses and classify bills as abortion-related if the word “abortion” appears in the bill text. We then calculate the proportion of abortion-related bills each legislator cosponsored before and after *Dobbs*. Estimating pre–post models similar to the in-text specifications, we find that Democratic female legislators increased abortion-bill cosponsorship relative to Republican female legislators by 0.8 percentage points ($\beta = 0.008, p = 0.006$), with no statistically significant change among male legislators ($\beta = 0.002, p = 0.26$). A pooled triple interaction, Post-*Dobbs* $\times$ Democrat $\times$ Female, indicates that this post-*Dobbs* partisan shift is larger among female legislators than among male legislators ($\beta = 0.006, p = 0.054$). Each model controls for the total number of abortion-related bills sponsored before and after *Dobbs*.

Conclusions

This paper demonstrates that landmark Supreme Court rulings can reshape congressional issue attention, but that these effects are selective rather than uniform. We develop an incentive-

correlate with effective lawmaking on the issue.

¹³See Appendix Section “Durability of Main Effects.”

alignment theory of congressional issue attention, arguing that legislators are most likely to respond to identity-linked cases when their representational incentives and party-based electoral incentives align. Using more than 1.6 million committee hearing statements, we show that female Democrats drove the post-*Dobbs* increase in congressional attention to abortion. For these legislators, abortion was both gender-salient and electorally advantageous to foreground. In contrast, female Republicans faced cross-cutting incentives: abortion remained a gender-salient issue, but *Dobbs* made abortion electorally costly for Republicans to elevate.

Our argument and findings have broad implications for the relationship between congressional representation and judicial decisions. *Dobbs* is a case in which the Court moved policy away from majority opinion on abortion (Jessee, Malhotra and Sen 2022; Clark et al. 2024). Whether, and which, legislators respond when the Court retrenches rights supported by most Americans speaks directly to Congress's capacity to represent public opinion. Our findings suggest that this responsiveness depends on whether identity and party create reinforcing incentives for legislators to increase attention to the issue.

Our findings also suggest that descriptive representation operates through partisan institutions rather than apart from them. Identity-linked incentives can heighten legislative responsiveness, but only when they are not constrained by party-based electoral pressures. Judicial decisions may therefore produce broad legislative attention when representational and electoral incentives align, but selective or muted attention when those incentives conflict.

Future research may wish to build on our incentive-alignment framework to examine whether similar dynamics emerge beyond abortion and beyond Congress. Although state legislatures have long been central to abortion policymaking, they now exercise even greater authority after *Dobbs*. Yet state legislatures differ from Congress in their membership, professionalism, media environments, and electoral pressures. These differences create an opportunity to further theorize and test when judicial decisions generate broad legislative responsiveness and when they produce the selective patterns documented in the U.S. Congress.

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Data

Committee Hearing Transcripts and Statements

We analyze nearly 1.6 million committee hearing statements drawn from 17,408 hearings held in the U.S. House of Representatives across the 105th–119th Congresses. Transcripts for the 105th–117th Congresses were obtained from publicly available replication files associated with Park (2021, 2025) (Park 2021; Ban, Park and You 2025). Transcripts for the 118th and 119th Congresses were scraped by the authors from `govinfo.gov` using the procedures described in Park (2021) (Park 2021). Scraping was completed on April 29, 2025; consequently, coverage for the 119th Congress includes hearings held on or before that date. Each hearing was parsed into individual statements (i.e., each unique time a legislator speaks). Witness statements were omitted. Statements were linked to legislators via GovTrack identification numbers, and legislators' gender and party were subsequently merged in.

***New York Times* Coverage and Legislators' E-Newsletters**

We supplement our committee hearing transcripts and statements dataset with an additional dataset that captures abortion coverage in the *New York Times*. Specifically, we collect the total monthly count of all *New York Times* articles published between January 2021 and December 2022, as well as the monthly count of unique articles that include either of the following two search strings: `abortion` and `Dobbs v. Jackson`. These measures capture variation in national media attention to abortion over time. Second, we identify the total monthly count of Members of Congress' e-newsletter releases to their constituents using D.C. Inbox, a database that archives all congressional e-newsletters in real time (Cormack 2025). We apply the same search strings and monthly date parameters to identify abortion- and *Dobbs*-related e-newsletters. Because e-newsletters reflect messages that members choose to send directly to constituents, they provide a complementary indicator of when legislators began receiving and transmitting information about *Dobbs*. For each data source, we calculate a monthly proportion representing the share of all articles (or e-newsletters) that mention abortion or *Dobbs* during that month. The numerator is the sum of all articles or e-newsletters matching the search criteria, and the denominator is the total count of all articles or e-newsletters published in that month, regardless of content. In total, we collect 182,329 *NYT* articles and 25,680 legislators' newsletters. These two data sources allow us to situate legislators' behavior within the broader information environment and to assess the timing of information flows around both the leak and the Court's final decision. We implement this approach for the six months preceding the first major action in the

case (certiorari granted) and the six months following the Court’s final action (the official decision release).

Labeling Abortion Statements

Bigram Dictionary Classification of Abortion Statements

We use a bigram dictionary classifier to identify legislators’ committee hearing statements that reference abortion (Lollis 2025). We evaluated several text classification strategies (including large language models), but selected a transparent bigram dictionary classification because it most accurately labeled abortion statements. First, we preprocessed the text by converting all words to lowercase, removing non-alphabetic characters, collapsing extra whitespace, and dropping stopwords, numbers, and punctuation. We then constructed a labeled training set by stratified sampling of 20,000 statements: 30% contained the term "abortion," and the remaining 70% were drawn at random from the corpus to ensure sufficient positive cases for training and evaluation. We used GPT-5 to label the 20,000 statements in the training set as abortion-related (1) or not (0) under explicit guidance to tag only unambiguous references. We use GPT-5 to classify statements because recent work demonstrates that ChatGPT outperforms human coders on classification tasks (Gilardi, Alizadeh and Kubli 2023). We held out 2,000 statements for out-of-sample validation. We randomly selected 2,000 statements from the 18,000 GPT-5 coded training statements and instructed human coders to label them. There was high classification agreement between GPT-5 and human coders (AUC = 0.94). In total, 2,678 of the 18,000 statements (17.4%) were labeled as abortion-related.

From the 2,678 positive statements, we extracted all bigrams (two-word sequences) yielding 81,103 bigram tokens. We then manually reviewed and removed bigrams that did not reliably indicate abortion, resulting in a dictionary of 1,829 abortion bigrams. The ten most frequent bigrams were `planned parenthood`, `pro life`, `roe wade`, `abortion ban`, `fund abortion`, `abortion service`, `hyde amendment`, `forced abortion`, `access abortion`, and `abortion clinic`. For classification, each corpus statement was coded as abortion-related if it (i) contained the token “abortion” or (ii) contained any abortion bigram; all other statements were not coded as abortion statements. The bigram classifier accurately predicted abortion statements in a validation set (that was held back prior to bigram selection) comparing GPT-5 and bigram-predicted classifications. Validation statistics include: Accuracy = 0.979; Precision = 0.904; Recall = 0.912; F1 = 0.907; AUC = 0.953; Cohen’s Kappa = 0.9. Our classifier identifies whether a statement references abortion; it does not code tone or policy position (e.g., pro-life vs. pro-choice). This design choice reflects two considerations. First, our outcome is legislators’

attention to abortion regardless of valence (positive/negative), function (substantive/symbolic), or policy direction (pro-life/pro-choice). Second, given that parties are increasingly internally homogeneous on policy issues (Lee 2016), especially highly partisan issues like abortion (Swers 2023), we expect that Republican statements are framed as pro-life while Democratic statements are framed as pro-choice. An additional measure of policy direction would add little information. Therefore, because our analyses focus on attention rather than stance, we do not code tone or policy direction.

Validating Abortion Labels

To validate our abortion labels, we held out 2,000 statements in a validation set prior to model training (i.e., these statements did not contribute to the bigram dictionary). We then compared GPT-5 labels to bigram-based predictions. The classifier closely matched the GPT-5 labels: accuracy = 0.979; precision = 0.904; recall = 0.912; F1 = 0.907; AUC = 0.953; Cohen's κ = 0.90. These statistics indicate that (i) GPT-5 produced reliable training labels and (ii) the bigram classifier accurately identified abortion statements in the corpus. Importantly, because the curated dictionary contains only bigrams that explicitly reference abortion (each reviewed by the authors), statements are coded as abortion-related only when they contain a hand-validated abortion bigram—minimizing the risk of false positives. To illustrate the dictionary's specificity, we list below the 50 most frequently occurring abortion bigrams: "plan parenthood" "pro life" "roe wade" "abort ban" "abort care" "reproduct health" "fund abort" "hyde amend" "abort servic" "birth abort" "perform abort" "partial birth" "provid abort" "abort provid" "gag rule" "forc abort" "access abort" "abort clinic" "ban abort" "pro choic" "global gag" "reproduct right" "seek abort" "pro abort" "unborn children" "anti abort" "fetal tissu" "reproduct healthcar" "termin pregnanc" "abort abort" "abort right" "late term" "term abort" "dobb decis" "cover abort" "overturn roe" "abort coverag" "select abort" "abort access" "includ abort" "life mother" "access reproduct" "pai abort" "restrict abort" "legal abort" "abort feder" "abort procedur" "protect life" "abort perform" "abort polici"

Outcome Measures

We construct our outcome measure, *Attention to Abortion*, using all U.S. House committee hearing statements made between the 105th and 119th Congresses. We restrict the sample to include only members who served in at least one congressional term before and after *Dobbs*. Our primary outcome, *Attention to Abortion*, measures the proportion of legislators' hearing statements that reference abortion. Statements are classified as pre-*Dobbs* or post-*Dobbs* using May 2, 2022—the date of the draft opinion leak—as the interruption date. We use two model specifications: a pre-post specification and a two-way fixed-effects (TWFE) specification.

For the pre-post interrupted time series (ITS) regression model specification, we aggregate statements across all Congresses before and after the *Dobbs* leak, collapsing to a single pre- and post-period observation per legislator:

$$Y_{ip} = \frac{1}{N_{ip}} \sum_{s=1}^{N_{ip}} A_{ips}, \quad (1)$$

where $p \in \{\text{pre}, \text{post}\}$ indicates whether statement s occurred before or after the *Dobbs* threshold, and N_{ip} denotes the total number of hearing statements made by legislator i during that period. The *Attention to Abortion (Pre-Post Dobbs)* outcome variable measures the proportion of a legislator's hearing statements that reference abortion before and after the *Dobbs* decision leaked.

For the two-way fixed-effects (TWFE) ITS specification, we compute abortion attention for each legislator i in each Congress t :

$$Y_{it} = \frac{1}{N_{it}} \sum_{s=1}^{N_{it}} A_{its}, \quad (2)$$

where $A_{its} = 1$ if statement s made by legislator i in Congress t references abortion and 0 otherwise, and N_{it} is the total number of hearing statements made by legislator i in Congress t . The *Attention to Abortion (by Term)* outcome variable measures the proportion of a legislator's hearing statements that reference abortion in each congressional term.

Each approach captures the same underlying construct—legislators’ proportional attention to abortion before and after *Dobbs*—but with a different unit of analysis. The unit of analysis for the pre-post ITS specification is legislator-period. The unit of analysis for the TWFE ITS specification is legislator-term.

Interrupted Time-Series Design

We estimate changes in legislators’ abortion attention following *Dobbs v. Jackson Women’s Health Organization* using three model specifications: (i) pre-post models with legislator fixed effects, estimated separately by gender; (ii) two-way fixed-effects (TWFE) models with legislator and term fixed effects, also estimated separately by gender; and (iii) pooled pre-post and TWFE models with triple interactions, estimated with legislator fixed effects and with both legislator and term fixed effects. The estimand in the gender-split models is the average *difference in the change* in abortion attention from the pre- to post-*Dobbs* period between Democrats and Republicans, estimated separately for female and male legislators. In the pooled models, the estimand of interest is whether this post-*Dobbs* Democratic-versus-Republican change differs between female and male legislators.

Sample inclusion: The universe of observations includes all members of the U.S. House of Representatives serving in the 105th–119th Congresses who made at least one committee hearing statement and served in at least one Congress both before and after *Dobbs*. This restriction ensures that estimates reflect within-legislator changes in speech rather than compositional changes in membership. Statements are coded as pre-*Dobbs* or post-*Dobbs* using May 2, 2022—the date of the draft opinion leak—as the interruption date.

Pre-post models by gender: Our first specification averages the proportion of legislators’ abortion statements before and after *Dobbs*. We then estimate a pre-post ITS model with a party and interruption-date interaction, with samples disaggregated by legislators’ gender:

$$Y_{ip} = \alpha + \beta_1(PostDobbs_p \times Democrat_i) + \mu_i + \varepsilon_{ip}, \quad (3)$$

where Y_{ip} denotes the proportion of hearing statements referencing abortion made by legislator i in period p , where $p \in \{\text{pre}, \text{post}\}$; $PostDobbs_p$ is an indicator equal to 1 for the post-*Dobbs* period and 0 otherwise; $Democrat_i$ indicates party affiliation; and μ_i are legislator fixed effects that absorb all time-invariant characteristics of individual members. The coefficient β_1 captures the average change in abortion attention among

Democrats relative to Republicans after *Dobbs*, estimated separately for female and male legislators.

TWFE models by gender: We next estimate a two-way fixed-effects (TWFE) panel model to account for unobserved heterogeneity across legislators and time:

$$Y_{it} = \alpha + \beta_1(PostDobbs_t \times Democrat_i) + \mu_i + \lambda_t + \varepsilon_{it}, \quad (4)$$

where Y_{it} denotes the proportion of hearing statements referencing abortion made by legislator i in Congress t ; μ_i are legislator fixed effects that absorb all time-invariant characteristics of individual members; and λ_t are Congress fixed effects that account for period-specific shocks common to all legislators. The coefficient β_1 again represents the differential change in abortion attention among Democrats relative to Republicans following *Dobbs*, estimated separately by gender.

Pooled triple-interaction models: Finally, we estimate pooled models that include female and male legislators in the same specification. The pre-post pooled model is:

$$\begin{aligned} Y_{ip} = & \alpha + \beta_1(PostDobbs_p \times Democrat_i) \\ & + \beta_2(PostDobbs_p \times Female_i) \\ & + \beta_3(Female_i \times Democrat_i) \\ & + \beta_4(PostDobbs_p \times Female_i \times Democrat_i) \\ & + \mu_i + \varepsilon_{ip}. \end{aligned} \quad (5)$$

The pooled TWFE model is:

$$\begin{aligned} Y_{it} = & \alpha + \beta_1(PostDobbs_t \times Democrat_i) \\ & + \beta_2(PostDobbs_t \times Female_i) \\ & + \beta_3(Female_i \times Democrat_i) \\ & + \beta_4(PostDobbs_t \times Female_i \times Democrat_i) \\ & + \mu_i + \lambda_t + \varepsilon_{it}. \end{aligned} \quad (6)$$

In the pooled models, the coefficient of interest is β_4 , the triple interaction between the post-*Dobbs*, female,

and Democratic Party indicators. This coefficient captures whether the post-*Dobbs* Democratic-versus-Republican change in abortion attention differs between female and male legislators.

Pre-Treatment Trends

Although our ITS design does not compare treated and untreated units, it still requires assessing whether the groups used to estimate differential changes were already moving in different directions before the *Dobbs* leak. If party- and gender-based differences in abortion attention were already widening prior to the leak, post-*Dobbs* divergence could reflect pre-existing trends rather than a response to the common shock.

In our study, the relevant interruption is the *Dobbs* draft opinion leak, and the outcome is the proportion of legislators' hearing statements referencing abortion. Because all legislators were exposed to the leaked decision, our ITS design estimates differential changes in abortion attention between Democrats and Republicans, disaggregated by gender. The relevant pre-trend diagnostic is therefore whether party- and gender-specific changes in abortion attention were stable prior to the leak. That is, groups could differ in their baseline level of attention to abortion, but there should be no evidence that abortion attention was already diverging systematically before *Dobbs*.

The main threat to identification arises if abortion attention was already diverging by party or gender before *Dobbs*—for instance, if Democratic female legislators were gradually increasing their attention relative to other groups. To assess this possibility, we implement a series of descriptive and model-based pre-trend checks. These include an alternative interruption-date specification, a randomization-in-time placebo test, evaluation of median pre-*Dobbs* differences by party and gender, a 16-month pre-*Dobbs* event study, and lagged fixed-effects estimations. Across all tests, we find no evidence of pre-existing divergence, supporting the credibility of our ITS design.

Alternative Interruption Date Specification

To assess whether similar shifts appear around other plausible event dates, we estimate the pre-/post-*Dobbs* ITS specification reported in the text using two alternative interruption dates: 1) the Court's grant of certiorari (May 17, 2021) and 2) the day of the official Court decision (June 24, 2022). As expected, the

party-based differences for each gender subgroup are substantively negligible and statistically insignificant when the interruption date corresponds to an event that occurred prior to the *Dobbs* leak (i.e., certiorari). When the interruption date is assigned to the day of the official decision, however, the observed results are consistent with the in-text results, reinforcing that the observed shift first appeared after the leak and remained durable through the date of the decision. The results from the alternative specifications are presented below in Appendix Table 1.

Appendix Table 1: Pre-Post Models of Abortion Statements by Event Date

	<i>DV: Proportion of Abortion Statements</i>			
	Cert Granted (May 17, 2021)		Official Decision (June 24, 2022)	
	Female Legislators	Male Legislators	Female Legislators	Male Legislators
Post Event	0.007* (0.004)	0.003*** (0.001)	−0.008** (0.004)	0.004* (0.002)
Democrat	0.006*** (0.002)	−0.006*** (0.001)	−0.008** (0.003)	0.008*** (0.002)
Post × Democrat	−0.001 (0.004)	−0.00004 (0.001)	0.022*** (0.006)	0.008 (0.006)
Intercept	−0.001 (0.002)	0.013*** (0.0004)	0.010*** (0.002)	0.011*** (0.001)
Legislator FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	235	585	208	540
Adjusted R ²	0.615	0.662	0.561	0.530

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Randomized Interruption Date Placebo Test

We conduct a randomization-in-time placebo test to assess whether randomly assigning the date of the *Dobbs* draft opinion leak produces comparable shifts in abortion attention. If the *Dobbs* leak marked the relevant interruption, randomly assigned pre-*Dobbs* dates should produce null results. To test this logic, we subset the corpus of unique committee hearing transcripts to include only hearings with a recorded date ($n = 17,357$). We then simulate 2,000 placebo interruption dates, each randomly drawn from the set of observed hearing dates that occurred prior to the *Dobbs* draft opinion leak on May 2, 2022. For each simulated

date, we reconstruct the pre/post indicator, calculating the proportion of abortion statements each legislator makes before and after the fictional leak dates. We then re-estimate the pre–post ITS model with legislator fixed effects by gender.

$$\text{share}_{i,\text{period}} \sim \text{PostDobbs} \times \text{Democrat} + \text{FE}_i$$

Members are retained in the sample only if they have observations on both sides of the simulated cutoff. Across 2,000 simulations, 98.2% of placebo models for female legislators and 97.4% for male legislators yield $p > 0.05$ on the *PostDobbs* $\times$ *Democrat* interaction term. Put differently, almost none of the randomly assigned pre-*Dobbs* dates produce a significant party-based shift in abortion attention. This pattern strengthens our claim that meaningful party-based differences by gender emerge only after the *Dobbs* draft opinion leak. See Panel C in Figure 2 (in-text).

Median Pre-*Dobbs* Differences in Abortion Attention by Gender and Party

Another way we assess pre-treatment trends is to examine differences in attention to abortion across congressional terms before *Dobbs*. For each Congress from the 105th through the 116th Congress (the last fully pre-*Dobbs* congressional term), we calculate the median difference between Democratic and Republican legislators in the share of committee hearing statements that reference abortion. We evaluate whether there are partisan gaps in abortion attention for female and male legislators prior to *Dobbs*. Across the pre-*Dobbs* period, the median partisan difference in abortion attention remained near zero across both samples. The absence of term-level party-based differences in attention to abortion indicates that both female and male legislators followed similar pre-*Dobbs* trajectories, providing no evidence of pre-existing divergence.

16-Month Pre-*Dobbs* Event Study

To conduct a stricter pre-trend check, we estimate a monthly event-study model that spans the 16 months preceding the *Dobbs* leak (January 2021–April 2022). More specifically, we estimate a regression model in which abortion attention is a function of monthly indicators for the pre-*Dobbs* period, interacting each with party, and including legislator fixed effects with robust standard errors clustered by legislator. Models are estimated separately by legislators’ gender. Across both female and male legislators, all pre-*Dobbs* monthly

coefficients are statistically indistinguishable from zero, and none exhibit any directional pattern. These findings indicate that even under this more sensitive, month-level specification, abortion attention among Democrats and Republicans did not diverge systematically prior to *Dobbs*. See Panel B in Figure 2 (in-text).

Lagged Two-Way Fixed Effects Estimation

To further demonstrate the absence of pre-*Dobbs* divergence, we also leverage a two-way fixed-effects (TWFE) estimator. The TWFE estimator allows us to estimate models with lagged post-*Dobbs* indicators, which serve as falsification tests for pre-interruption differences. If attention to abortion had already begun diverging at an unbalanced rate between Democrats and Republicans prior to *Dobbs*, these lagged coefficients would differ significantly from zero. We estimate separate TWFE models for female and male legislators, lagging the *Dobbs* post-interruption indicator by one, two, and three congressional terms. Each model includes legislator and term fixed effects. The lag coefficients capture the estimated shift associated with *Dobbs* when the post-interruption indicator is artificially imposed on earlier periods, allowing us to detect premature divergence in each party's attention to abortion from one Congress to the next, by gender group. Across all specifications, the lagged coefficients are near zero and are not statistically significant. The absence of systematic lagged effects indicates that abortion attention did not diverge systematically prior to *Dobbs*. See Panel D in Figure 2 (in-text).

Alternative Model Specifications

In-Text Model Results & Alternative Specifications

The main models reported in-text show that Democratic women increase the share of their committee statements referencing abortion by roughly two percentage points more than Republican women after *Dobbs*, with no effect among men. As robustness checks, we estimate a series of pre-post models that include various combinations of post-*Dobbs*, gender, and party indicators without subsetting by gender. A model with only a post-*Dobbs* indicator suggests that legislators, on average, make more abortion statements after the decision than before ($\beta = 0.007; p = 0.000$). Models that include only a party indicator show no statistically significant difference in attention to abortion after *Dobbs* ($\beta = 0.002; p = 0.18$). Models that include only a gender indicator are statistically significant, indicating that female legislators made slightly more abortion statements than male legislators prior to *Dobbs* ($\beta = 0.004; p = 0.05$). Models that interact a post-

Dobbs indicator with either a gender or a party indicator (while dropping legislator fixed effects) suggest that Democrats were more likely to mention abortion after *Dobbs* than Republicans ($\beta = 0.008$; $p = 0.04$); however, no such difference exists between male and female legislators ($\beta = 0.001$; $p = 0.80$). These results, presented in Appendix Table 2, support our argument that legislators' responses were shaped by gender and party (not one or the other). Finally, a model with a triple interaction between post-*Dobbs*, gender, and party yields a coefficient of 0.017 ($p = 0.02$), indicating that the post-*Dobbs* increase in the Democrat–Republican gap in abortion attention was larger among female legislators than among male legislators.

Appendix Table 2: Subcomponents of Design Predicting Abortion Statements

	DV: Proportion of Abortion Statements					
	1	2	3	4	5	6
Post <i>Dobbs</i>	0.007*** (0.002)			0.003 (0.002)	0.007*** (0.002)	0.005** (0.003)
Female		0.004* (0.002)			−0.008 (0.009)	−0.023*** (0.003)
Democrat			0.003 (0.002)	0.008*** (0.002)		0.009*** (0.003)
Post <i>Dobbs</i> x Female					0.001 (0.004)	−0.014*** (0.004)
Post <i>Dobbs</i> x Democrat				0.008** (0.004)		0.004 (0.005)
Female x Democrat						0.030*** (0.005)
Post <i>Dobbs</i> x Female x Democrat						0.017** (0.007)
Intercept	0.010*** (0.001)	0.006*** (0.001)	0.006*** (0.001)	0.012*** (0.001)	0.010*** (0.001)	0.011*** (0.001)
Legislator FE	✓	✗	✗	✓	✓	✓
Observations	788	788	788	788	788	788
Adjusted R ²	0.529	0.004	0.002	0.534	0.529	0.538

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Committee Fixed Effects

In the main text, we do not include committee fixed effects because our interest is Congress-wide attention to abortion rather than committee-specific effects. One concern, however, is selection: legislators who wish to speak about abortion may sort into issue-relevant committees, creating more opportunities to make abortion statements. To address this alternative explanation, we re-estimate our TWFE model with member, term, and committee fixed effects at the legislator–committee–term level. The outcome variable is the proportion of a legislator’s statements in a given committee–term that reference abortion. The independent variable is the interaction between a post-*Dobbs* indicator and a Democratic Party indicator, and we estimate models separately by gender. Results are robust. Among women, Democrats referenced abortion about one percentage point more than Republican women ($p = 0.05$). Among men, Democrats and Republicans did not differ ($\beta = 0.00$, $p = 0.80$). These patterns indicate that committee selection is unlikely to drive our main findings.

Appendix Table 3: Main TWFE Model with Committee Fixed Effects

	<i>DV: Proportion of Abortion Statements</i>	
	Female Legislators	Male Legislators
Post <i>Dobbs</i>	−0.009 (0.006)	−0.0004 (0.003)
Democrat	−0.015** (0.006)	−0.004*** (0.001)
Post <i>Dobbs</i> × Democrat	0.010* (0.005)	0.001 (0.003)
Intercept	0.006 (0.006)	0.0002 (0.003)
Legislator FE	✓	✓
Committee FE	✓	✓
Term FE	✓	✓
Observations	2,885	10,296
Adjusted R ²	0.124	0.140

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Logged Share of Abortion Attention

The outcome variable, attention to abortion, is right-skewed: most legislators make few abortion statements per period, while a minority make many. To ensure that this skewness does not drive our results, we apply a natural-log transformation to the dependent variables, $\log(y + 1)$. Results are substantively unchanged across both specifications. In the pre-post model, Democratic women make about 2 percentage points more abortion statements than Republican women ($p = 0.000$), while the party difference among men is not statistically significant ($p = 0.38$). The TWFE model shows the same pattern (**Women:** $\beta = 0.008$, $p = 0.02$; **Men:** $\beta = -0.0003$, $p = 0.72$).

Appendix Table 4: Logged Proportion of Abortion Statements Model Specification

	<i>DV: Logged Proportion of Abortion Statements</i>			
	Female Legislators		Male Legislators	
	Pre-Post	TWFE	Pre-Post	TWFE
Post <i>Dobbs</i>	−0.008** (0.004)	−0.010** (0.004)	0.005** (0.002)	−0.003 (0.003)
Democrat	−0.008*** (0.002)	−0.009** (0.004)	0.009*** (0.002)	−0.003*** (0.001)
Post <i>Dobbs</i> × Democrat	0.021*** (0.005)	0.008** (0.004)	0.004 (0.004)	−0.0003 (0.001)
Intercept	0.010*** (0.002)	0.010** (0.004)	0.011*** (0.001)	0.004 (0.003)
Legislator FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Term FE	✗	✓	✗	✓
Observations	226	1,117	562	4,562
Adjusted R ²	0.587	0.409	0.530	0.304

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Frequency-Weighted Model

To ensure our findings are not driven by differences in statement volume, we re-estimate both specifications using frequency weights equal to each member-period's total number of statements, retaining legislator fixed effects and clustering standard errors by member. Results are substantively unchanged. In the pre-post

model, Democratic women mention abortion 1.16 percentage points more than Republican women post-*Dobbs* ($p = 0.000$), while the partisan gap among men is not statistically significant ($\beta = 0.001$, $p = 0.43$). The TWFE specification yields the same pattern: Democratic women mention abortion 0.6 percentage points more than Republican women after *Dobbs* ($p = 0.02$), with no significant party difference among men ($p = 0.40$). These weighted estimates closely track the unweighted results, indicating that our findings are not driven by variation in total statement volume.

Appendix Table 5: Frequency-Weighted Models of Abortion Attention by Gender (Log Outcome)

<i>DV: Logged Proportion of Abortion Statements</i>				
	Female Legislators		Male Legislators	
	Pre-Post	TWFE	Pre-Post	TWFE
Post <i>Dobbs</i>	−0.004*** (0.001)	−0.008** (0.004)	0.003*** (0.001)	−0.0002 (0.002)
Democrat	0.001* (0.001)	−0.010*** (0.004)	0.007*** (0.001)	−0.002** (0.001)
Post <i>Dobbs</i> × Democrat	0.011*** (0.002)	0.006** (0.003)	0.001 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)
Intercept	0.007*** (0.001)	0.008** (0.004)	0.006*** (0.0001)	0.001 (0.001)
Legislator FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Term FE	✗	✓	✗	✓
Observations	226	1,117	562	4,562
Adjusted R ²	0.603	0.469	0.661	0.444

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Durability of Main Effects

We assess how long the increase in attention to abortion among Democratic women persists after *Dobbs* by splitting the post period into three bins: the second half of the 117th Congress (on/after May 2, 2022), the 118th, and the 119th. For male and female legislators, we estimate a TWFE model with legislator fixed effects and period dummies, using the share of a legislator’s hearing statements that reference abortion before and after as the outcome. The independent variable is an interaction term between the post-*Dobbs* indicator

and Democrat, which captures the differential change by party, relative to the pre-*Dobbs* period. We then conduct Wald tests of (i) joint significance of all post-*Dobbs* interactions and (ii) equality of effects across the three post bins. For women, the joint post-*Dobbs* effect is statistically significant (**Wald** $\chi^2(3) = 8.95$, $p = 0.03$); for men it is not ($\chi^2(3) = 2.58$, $p = 0.46$). Effects are statistically indistinguishable across the three post bins for both women and men (**Women:** $\chi^2(2) = 0.25$, $p = 0.884$; **Men:** $\chi^2(2) = 2.23$, $p = 0.328$), indicating that the post-*Dobbs* increase among Democratic female legislators persists through the 119th Congress without detectable decay and that no comparable increase appears among male legislators. Point estimates for women are roughly 1.5 to 2.3 percentage points across bins.

Contextualizing the Magnitude of the *Dobbs* Effect

Our results indicate that Democratic female legislators increased their attention to abortion by roughly two percentage points relative to Republican female legislators after *Dobbs*, with no comparable party-based change among male legislators. Is a two percentage point shift in committee hearing attention substantively large? To contextualize the magnitude of this estimate, we compare the post-*Dobbs* shift to changes in abortion attention around other major abortion-policy events that occur in our time series.

We examine four consequential abortion-policy events: passage of the Partial-Birth Abortion Ban Act (November 5, 2003), *Gonzalez v. Carhart* (April 18, 2007), *Whole Woman's Health v. Hellerstedt* (June 27, 2016), and *June Medical Services, LLC v. Russo* (June 29, 2020). For each event, we estimate pre-post ITS models comparing proportional attention to abortion before and after the event, separately by gender, using the same party-based interaction reported in the main text. These analyses are intended as descriptive benchmarks for the magnitude of the *Dobbs* effect, not as additional tests of the incentive-alignment theory.

This distinction is important. Our theory does not imply that every abortion-related event should generate a statistically significant increase in attention among Democratic female legislators. Instead, we expect the strongest shifts when identity-linked representational incentives and party-based electoral incentives align. Although each event examined here involved abortion, not all created the same electoral context as *Dobbs*. Some occurred before abortion became as electorally central to Democratic campaign strategy, while others did not create comparable incentives for Republicans to avoid the issue. As a result, smaller or statistically insignificant shifts around these events do not cut against the theory. They instead provide a useful bench-

mark: compared with other major abortion-policy events in our time series, *Dobbs* produced the largest party-based increase in abortion attention among female legislators.

Appendix Tables 6–9 help contextualize the substantive magnitude of the post-*Dobbs* effect by comparing it to changes in congressional attention around other major abortion-policy events. These comparisons show that all four events produced smaller party-based changes in abortion attention among female legislators than *Dobbs*. Three of the four events produced statistically insignificant changes among female legislators. The exception is *Whole Woman’s Health v. Hellerstedt*, after which Democratic female legislators increased attention relative to Republican female legislators; however, the estimated increase is substantively small, approximately 0.2 percentage points (one-tenth the size of the post-*Dobbs* estimate reported in the main text). Against this benchmark, the roughly two percentage point post-*Dobbs* shift is large: it is an order of magnitude larger than the only statistically significant comparison event and larger than the shifts observed around any other major abortion-policy event in the congressional hearing record. These descriptive comparisons provide evidence that a two percentage point change in abortion attention is substantively meaningful in the context of committee hearing speech.

Appendix Table 6: TWFE Models of Abortion Attention — Partial-Birth Abortion Ban (2003)

	<i>DV: Proportion of Abortion Statements</i>			
	Female Legislators		Male Legislators	
	Pre-Post	TWFE	Pre-Post	TWFE
Post Treatment	−0.00002 (0.001)	−0.00002 (0.001)	−0.0004 (0.001)	−0.0004 (0.001)
Democrat	0.004*** (0.001)	0.004*** (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)
Post × Democrat	0.003 (0.002)	0.003 (0.002)	−0.002 (0.002)	−0.002 (0.002)
Intercept	0.00001 (0.0005)	0.00001 (0.0005)	0.0002 (0.0004)	0.0002 (0.0004)
Legislator FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Term FE	✗	✓	✗	✓
Observations	112	112	686	686
Adjusted R ²	0.604	0.604	0.557	0.557

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Appendix Table 7: TWFE Models of Abortion Attention — *Gonzalez v. Carhart* (2007)

	<i>DV: Proportion of Abortion Statements</i>			
	Female Legislators		Male Legislators	
	Pre-Post	TWFE	Pre-Post	TWFE
Post Treatment	0.001 (0.001)	0.001 (0.001)	0.00004 (0.001)	0.00004 (0.001)
Democrat	0.010*** (0.001)	0.010*** (0.001)	0.001 (0.0004)	0.001 (0.0004)
Post × Democrat	−0.0003 (0.001)	−0.0003 (0.001)	0.0001 (0.001)	0.0001 (0.001)
Intercept	−0.001 (0.001)	−0.001 (0.001)	−0.00002 (0.0003)	−0.00002 (0.0003)
Legislator FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Term FE	✗	✓	✗	✓
Observations	136	136	720	720
Adjusted R ²	0.755	0.755	0.651	0.651

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Appendix Table 8: TWFE Models of Abortion Attention — *Whole Woman’s Health v. Hellerstedt* (2016)

	<i>DV: Proportion of Abortion Statements</i>			
	Female Legislators		Male Legislators	
	Pre-Post	TWFE	Pre-Post	TWFE
Post Treatment	−0.001 (0.001)	−0.001 (0.001)	−0.0004 (0.0004)	−0.0004 (0.0004)
Democrat	−0.003*** (0.001)	−0.003*** (0.001)	−0.006*** (0.0003)	−0.006*** (0.0003)
Post × Democrat	0.002* (0.001)	0.002* (0.001)	0.0001 (0.001)	0.0001 (0.001)
Intercept	0.003*** (0.0004)	0.003*** (0.0004)	0.007*** (0.0002)	0.007*** (0.0002)
Legislator FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Term FE	✗	✓	✗	✓
Observations	174	174	654	654
Adjusted R ²	0.570	0.570	0.699	0.699

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Appendix Table 9: TWFE Models of Abortion Attention — *June Medical Services v. Russo* (2020)

	<i>DV: Proportion of Abortion Statements</i>			
	Female Legislators		Male Legislators	
	Pre-Post	TWFE	Pre-Post	TWFE
Post Treatment	0.003 (0.003)	0.003 (0.003)	0.002*** (0.001)	0.002*** (0.001)
Democrat	−0.001 (0.002)	−0.001 (0.002)	−0.013*** (0.0004)	−0.013*** (0.0004)
Post × Democrat	−0.0003 (0.003)	−0.0003 (0.003)	−0.0003 (0.001)	−0.0003 (0.001)
Intercept	−0.0003 (0.001)	−0.0003 (0.001)	0.012*** (0.0003)	0.012*** (0.0003)
Legislator FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
Term FE	✗	✓	✗	✓
Observations	208	208	588	588
Adjusted R ²	0.681	0.681	0.683	0.683

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Alternative Dependent Variable: Cosponsorship of Abortion Bills

To assess whether our findings are robust to additional measures of issue attention, we examine legislators’ cosponsorship of abortion bills. To do so, we collect data on legislators’ cosponsorship decisions from the 111th–118th Congresses. We classify bills as abortion-related if the word “abortion” appears in the bill text. We then compute the proportion of abortion bills each legislator cosponsored before and after *Dobbs*.

Estimating a pre-post model similar to the in-text specification, we find that female Democrats increased abortion-bill cosponsorship relative to female Republicans by 0.8 percentage points ($\beta = 0.008$, $p = 0.006$), with no statistically significant change among men ($\beta = 0.002$, $p = 0.26$). A triple interaction (Post-*Dobbs* × Democrat × Female) indicates that the post-*Dobbs* partisan shift is larger among women than among men ($\beta = 0.006$, $p = 0.054$). In each model, we control for the number of abortion bills before and after *Dobbs*. Overall, these additional models show that the post-*Dobbs* gendered partisan shift is not limited to committee hearings; it also extends to cosponsorship behavior. Together, they indicate that *Dobbs* reshaped legislators’

behavior at multiple decision points in the legislative process.

Appendix Table 10: TWFE Models of Cosponsorship of Abortion Bills by Gender

	<i>DV: Proportion of Cosponsored Bills Related to Abortion</i>		
	Female Legislators	Male Legislators	Full Interaction
<i>Post Dobbs</i>	−0.006** (0.003)	−0.001 (0.002)	−0.001 (0.002)
Democrat	−0.007*** (0.001)	−0.006*** (0.001)	−0.006*** (0.001)
Post Dobbs × Democrat	0.008*** (0.003)	−0.046*** (0.0004)	
Post Dobbs × Democrat × Female			0.006* (0.003)
Number of Unique Abortion Bills (Period)	0.008*** (0.003)	0.002 (0.002)	0.002 (0.002)
Intercept	0.010*** (0.001)	0.055*** (0.001)	0.055*** (0.001)
Legislator FE	✓	✓	✓
Term FE	✓	✓	✓
Observations	254	631	885
Adjusted R ²	0.732	0.748	0.753

Note: Standard errors are clustered by legislator and are reported in parentheses. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Placebo Tests: Non-Abortion Issue Areas

As an additional robustness check, we implement a series of negative outcome controls to assess whether the observed post-*Dobbs* shifts in congressional attention are specific to abortion. If our findings are specific to *Dobbs*, and are not produced in other issue areas, this suggests that *Dobbs* likely drives the gender- and electoral-based shifts reported in-text. To do so, we examine whether *Dobbs* is associated with changes in legislators' attention to a set of policy issue areas that are theoretically unrelated to abortion. Using the keyword dictionaries below, we construct measures of issue attention for the following issue areas: housing, guns, immigration, environment, policing, agriculture, and economics.

Housing:housing, affordable housing, public housing, homeless, homelessness, rent, renter, eviction, mortgage, property tax, housing assistance, HUD, low-income housing, housing development, section 8, tenant, housing crisis, subsidized housing, housing policy, housing stability

Guns:2nd amendment, right to bear arms, second amendment, nra, rifle, firearm, gun violence, shootings, assault rifle, assault weapon, automatic weapon, background checks, background check, bump stock, high-capacity magazine, gun, guns

Immigration:immigration, immigrant, border, asylum, refugee, deportation, undocumented, illegal immigrant, visa, green card, citizenship, naturalization, DACA, ICE, customs and border protection, border security, migrant, migration, immigration policy, immigration reform

Environment:environment, environmental, climate change, global warming, greenhouse, pollution, polluting, pollutants, polluters, fossil fuel

Police: defund the police, abolish, law enforcement, policing, back the blue, police, officer, officers

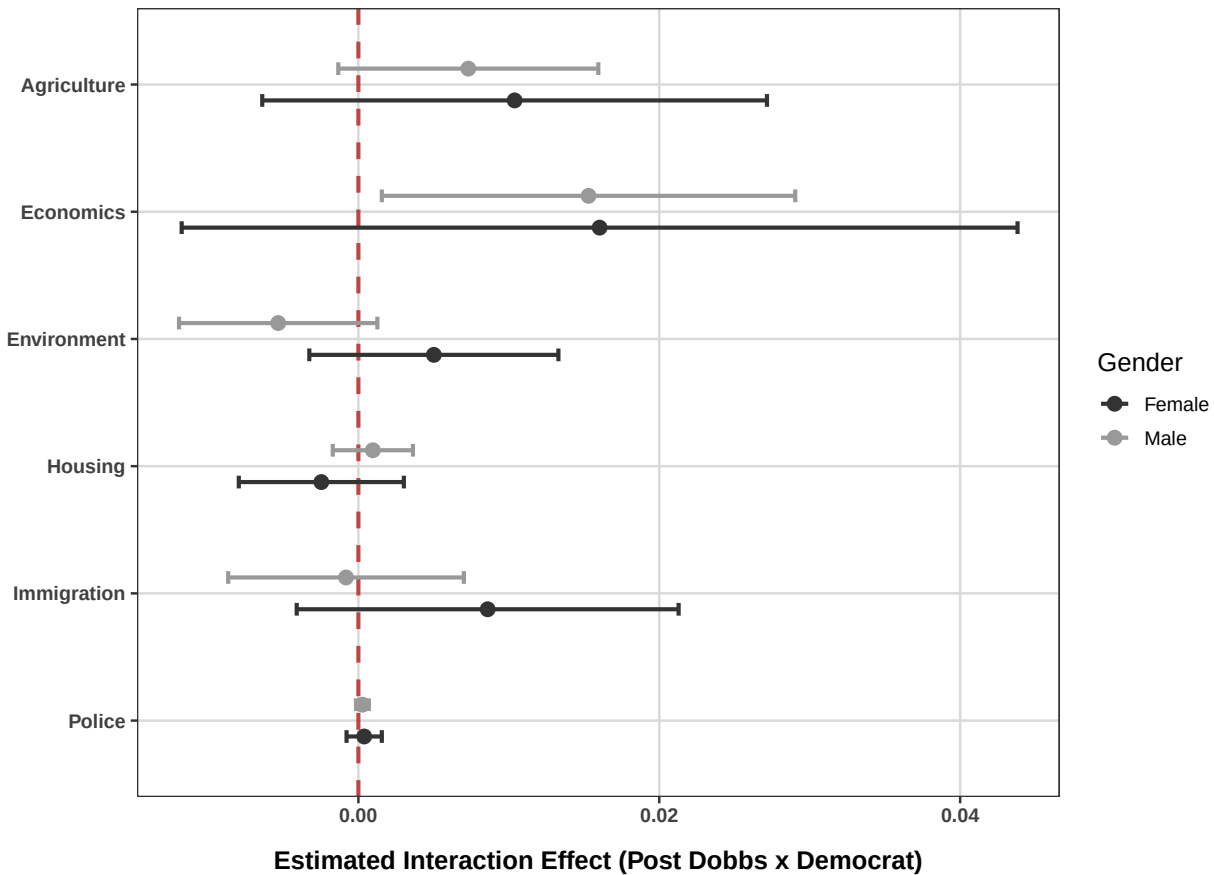
Agriculture:agriculture, farm, farmer, farming, crops, livestock, agricultural policy, federal farm program, agricultural trade, food security, agribusiness

Economics:economy, gdp, jobs, unemployment, inflation, federal reserve, interest rate, budget, trade, tariff, fiscal policy, monetary policy, deficit, recession, financial regulation

Each dictionary consists of substantively relevant terms commonly used in congressional discourse. We then re-estimate our pre-post models using each alternative issue attention measure as the dependent variable. *Dobbs* should not systematically affect attention to these unrelated policy domains. Accordingly, we expect null or substantively negligible estimates for the post-*Dobbs* interaction terms in these placebo outcomes. Appendix Figure 1 plots the estimated post-*Dobbs* interaction effects by policy area, separately for male and female legislators. Across all domains, point estimates are small in magnitude and confidence intervals consistently overlap zero. Importantly, there is no systematic pattern by gender or policy area that would suggest a generalized reorientation of issue attention following *Dobbs*. Consistent with these expectations, we find no evidence that *Dobbs* produced meaningful shifts in legislative attention outside the abortion domain. The absence of an effect in other policy areas strengthens our claim that *Dobbs* increased female

Democrats attention to abortion, rather than a broader contemporaneous change in congressional attention.

Appendix Figure 1: Non-Abortion Policy Attention Does Not Increase After *Dobbs*



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